This fragrant soup takes the best ingredients from a cottage garden in the southern Indian state of Kerala. If you are using dried curry leaves, add them with the stock.

keralan shrimp soup

SERVES 4–6 **PREP** 20 MINS **COOK** 40 MINS **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

1 tsp black peppercorns
¾ tsp mustard seeds
2 tsp coriander seeds
½ tsp fenugreek seeds
2–3 large red chiles, coarsely chopped
4 garlic cloves, chopped
2in (5cm) piece fresh ginger, chopped
4 tbsp hot water
2–3 tbsp vegetable oil
small handful of fresh curry leaves
2 onions, finely chopped
3¼ cups fish stock
1 cup coconut milk
9oz (250g) raw jumbo shrimp, shelled
1 tbsp coconut cream
2 tbsp fresh cilantro, chopped
juice of 1 lime, to taste

1 Heat a sturdy frying pan over low heat. Roast the peppercorns, mustard, coriander, and fenugreek seeds for about 30 seconds, until they give off a spicy aroma and the mustard seeds start to pop. Grind the spices to a powder using a mortar and pestle, and set aside.

2 Put the chiles in a small food processor with the garlic and ginger. (If you like a milder flavor, use just 2 chiles and remove the seeds.) Pour in the hot water and process to a paste. Set aside.

3 Heat the oil in a wok or saucepan. When hot, toss in the curry leaves and cook for 20 seconds, Be careful; curry leaves spit when added to hot oil. Add the onions, cover, and soften for 10 minutes, stirring occasionally.

4 Stir in the chile, garlic, and ginger paste and cook for 2–3 minutes, until the water evaporates. Add the ground spice mixture and cook for another 30 seconds, stirring all the time. Pour in the stock and simmer for 20 minutes or until reduced by one-third. Stir in the coconut milk and reheat before adding the shrimp and cooking for another 4–5 minutes. Add the coconut cream and finish with the cilantro and enough lime juice to sharpen.